

Topic: History and Importance of Hadith

Sub Topics: Methods of Examination of Hadith.

Q (a) Explain the importance of Isnad (Chain of transmitters) & of the Matan (body of text) in assisting scholars to check authenticity of Hadith. [10]

or

Q (a) Describe the methods employed by the compilers of the major books of Hadith to ensure the Hadiths they collected were authentic. [10]

Structure of Answer		
Para 1	Para 2	Para 3
☐ Introduction.	☐ Rules of Isnad (Chain of Narrators)	☐ Rules of Matan (Text of Hadith)
Answer		
☐ Major compilation of Hadith started years after Prophet's demise and during those years preservation and transition of Hadith depended upon the memory of people.		
☐ When official compilation began, It became necessary to devise a proper mechanism to examine Hadith and determine if the Hadith is authentic or not.		
☐ Compilers of Hadith divided Hadiths into two parts: Isnad (Chain of Narrators) and Matan (Text of Hadith)		
☐ Example:  "Muhammd bin Al Muthanna reported from Abdul Wahab from Ayub from Abu Killabah, from Malik that the Prophet said" = Isnad (Chain)  "Pray as you have seen me offering prayer" Matan (Text)		
☐ The first part which mentions the chain of transmitters is the Sanad and the second part which the body or text is the Matan. The scholars assessed both parts of the Hadith religiously.		
☐ Scholars and compilers of Hadith employed some very strict rules to check authenticity of Hadith through examination of Isnad (the chain of narrators).		
☐ They established a proper science called ' Asma-ur-Rijal ' (Names/Biographies of People/Narrators). They researched, gathered, compiled and published the data regarding detailed biographies of Hadith narrators in which they would determine the level of a narrator according to different parameters which would eventually affect the quality of Hadith. Imam Muhammad bin Sireen (RA) said regarding importance of examination of Hadith:  "Indeed this knowledge is the religion, so be careful with regards to the one whom you take your religion from." [Muqaddima Sahiha]		
☐ Rules employed by compilers of Hadith to check the authenticity of Hadith using Isnad are: ✓ Each transmitter must be honest, upright and strong Muslim. Because narrating Hadith of Holy Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) is a sacred duty that requires above mentioned standards. ✓ Transmitter must have good retention skills. Retaining can be of two types, it can be done through writing or through memorizing. ✓ There should be no gap, weaknesses or any other error in the chain from start till the end. Each transmitter must have known the transmitter before him, and also the transmitter after. ✓ The first transmitter in the chain must be a Companion of the Prophet (PBUH) as a successor narrating a Hadith directly from Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) is not considered an authentic connected Hadith.		
☐ Scholars and compilers of Hadith employed some very strict rules to check authenticity of Hadith through examination of Matan (the text of Hadith). Some of those rules are: ✓ The text of Hadith must agree with the fundamental principles and teachings of Quran. Any Hadith that contradicts		



with Quran can never be accepted as Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) could never say/do/approve anything that is against Quran. For instance a Madu Hadith says: "This world's age is seven thousand years and we are in the seventh thousand." This contradicts the verse of Quran in which Allah says that accurate knowledge of Judgement day is with Allah (SWT).

- ✓ It must also agree with the main body of famous and reliable Hadiths. An unknown Hadith that is not narrated by more than one companion, contradicts a famous and known Hadith will automatically be rejected.
- ✓ It must also agree with common sense and what is reasonable. For instance, a Madu Hadith says: "Long beard indicates stupidity." Or another one says: "Do not slice the meat with knife as it is the method of non-Arabs."
- ✓ A Hadith should not promise a huge reward for a tiny deed or huge punishment for a tiny sin.
- ✓ It should not praise/condemn any individual or place. For instance: "stay away from Hindus and Jews." Or another one says: "four cities are part of Hell, Constantinople, Tabriah, Intakiah and San'aa."
- ✓ It should not give precise details of events that occurred after the Prophet's time as Prophet (PBUH) would never predict any future incident with mention of exact time and date. For instance: "My companions will be faithful and practicing Muslims for 40 years, they will be loving and brotherly for 80 years and they will be full of hate after 160 years. Then there will be mischief and chaos."
- ✓ It should not contain expressions uncharacteristic of the Prophet as He had the most decent and sophisticated personality. So any use of abusive, indecent or immoral expression is impossible by Prophet Muhammad (PBUH).

Q (b) Why is it important for Muslims to have collections of authentic Hadiths? [4]

Answer

- ❑ Prophet (PBUH) has been designated as the best role model for Muslims and they were ordered to follow him, as Allah says:
 ﴿There has certainly been for you in the Messenger of Allah an excellent pattern﴾ [33:21]
 Thus it was necessary to compile his original sayings and actions.
- ❑ Further elaboration of Quran depends upon Hadith as Quran is a precise text that needs elaboration. Like Quran only orders to offer prayer but the number, pattern and other details will be found in Hadith.
- ❑ Hadith is the 2nd most important pillar of legal thinking in Islam. Without Sahih Ahadith it is impossible to compile and apply the accurate Islamic jurisprudence and Shariah Laws.
- ❑ If there was no authentic collection of Hadith, Ummah would have been further divided into more sects and groups. Authentic collection of Hadith ensures unity of Muslim Ummah.

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